the Sabbath. Rabin remembered the government crisis that had broken out in 1976 following the landing ceremony for the first F-16s that arrived in Israel, which had taken place after the start of the Sabbath, and he was not willing to risk another crisis of this sort. Another problem was that the Indonesians had stipulated that the meeting be kept secret by both sides until its conclusion. They announced categorically that if news of the meeting were leaked prior to its taking place, the prime minister's plane would not receive a landing permit from the control tower of the Jakarta airport.

The biggest challenge was hiding from the dozen or so Israeli journalists who had been invited by the prime minister to participate in his important trip to China the fact that after the visit they would suddenly find themselves in Indonesia. Before the trip, they were briefed that following the visit to China the prime minister's plane would be flying west and refueling in Azerbaijan and that from there it would continue to Nairobi for a meeting between the prime minister and the president of Kenya before the return to Israel.

After midnight between Thursday and Friday, I received a phone call at my hotel room in Shanghai. It was Danny Yatom, the prime minister's military secretary, inviting me to come up to the prime minister's suite. There, in addition to Yitzhak Rabin, his wife Leah, and Danny Yatom, were the prime minister's bureau chief Eitan Haber, director general of the Prime Minister's Office Shimon Sheves, and the captain of the plane. The problem: the captain was required to fill out a flight plan and distribute it to the control towers in Shanghai and Jakarta as well as to his headquarters in Israel. If he were to write that his next destination was Jakarta, the result would almost definitely be a leak of the meeting, which would surely be canceled as a result. The second issue was when and what to explain to the journalists traveling with the prime minister.

After some discussion, it was agreed that the captain would fill out the flight plan details according to the route of the cover story, namely Shanghai to Azerbaijan to Nairobi to Tel Aviv. The journalists would be informed about Jakarta near the time of landing. The following day, Friday, we took off from Shanghai as planned. During the flight, the prime minister went to the back of the plane to talk to the members of the press. One of the journalists accompanied him back to the front, and Yitzhak introduced him to me and asked that I brief him so that he could fill in the rest of the